

Contract templates, scope definition frameworks, client communication scripts for boundary-setting — Action Checklist

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CONTRACT FOUNDATIONS

□ **Contract Type:** Write down which contract template fits your primary work type before your next engagement so boundaries become self-enforcing from the start. Use deliverable-based for defined outputs, hourly for uncertain scope, and retainer for ongoing relationships. Revision Limits: State the exact number of revision rounds included in your price, define what counts as a revision, and specify the rate for additional rounds. Without this language, clients will expect unlimited changes at no extra cost. Payment Milestones: Structure payment into deposits, progress payments, and final payment tied to specific project phases, never starting work without a deposit and never finishing without final payment secured. This gives you leverage to ensure you actually get paid. Kill Fee Clause: Add a kill fee specifying what percentage of remaining contract value you receive if the client cancels mid-project without cause. This protects you from investing time in work that gets canceled and leaves you uncompensated. Deliverable Decomposition: Break every project into concrete, signable pieces that define exactly what the client is buying and what falls outside the agreement. The more specific your deliverables, the fewer grey areas exist for clients to exploit. IP Transfer Language: Include a clause stating intellectual property transfers to the client only upon final payment, retaining ownership until you're fully compensated. This gives you legal leverage when clients delay payment or dispute invoices. Scope Change Process: Define how clients request, approve, and pay for changes to the original scope, requiring all out-of-scope work to be formally approved before you begin. This prevents casual mentions of extra work from becoming expectations included in the original price. Non-Negotiables Document: Write down your essential contract clauses before client engagements so you know exactly what you will not compromise on. Without written non-negotiables, most freelancers bend under pressure because they have no clear reference point. Scope Boundary Script: Use a word-for-word script when clients request work outside the agreed scope, clearly explaining what is included versus what requires additional payment. Having the script ready removes the awkwardness of improvising boundary conversations. Contract Reference: When clients push for free extras, reference the specific contract clause they signed and reframe their request as a change requiring approval and additional payment. This removes the personal conflict by shifting focus to what was already agreed. Regular Check-Ins: Schedule recurring check-ins throughout projects to catch scope drift early before it compounds into large uncompensated work batches. Early detection lets you address misunderstandings before you've already invested free hours. Immediate Recovery: When scope has already slipped, renegotiate immediately rather than continuing to absorb hours, using the contract's scope change process to formally approve and bill for the additional work. Addressing the problem right away preserves the relationship and ensures you get paid.

□ **Check the Full Guide:** This step is described in detail in the companion guide — open [scope-creep-playbook-freelancers.md](#) and review the relevant section.

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SCOPE DEFINITION

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BOUNDARY SCRIPTS

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